

Collective Intelligence — Module 03: Perception — Discussion Questions

20 unique questions on collective sensing, wisdom of crowds, and perceptual diversity.

1. How does collective perception differ from simply averaging individual observations?
2. Under what conditions does the "wisdom of crowds" work, and under what conditions does it fail?
3. Information cascades can cause an entire group to converge on the wrong answer. Describe a business situation where this has happened. How could structured elicitation have prevented it?
4. The "shared information bias" means groups spend most discussion time on things everyone already knows. Why does this occur, and how can meeting design counteract it?
5. How does perceptual diversity (different people noticing different things) contribute to better collective sensing? When can diversity hurt perception?
6. Compare how a cross-functional team and a homogeneous specialist team perceive a complex problem. What are the trade-offs?
7. How do prediction markets aggregate collective perception? What makes them more effective than traditional forecasting?
8. Describe the role of "devil's advocate" in improving collective perception. Why is an assigned contrarian role more effective than hoping someone will naturally disagree?
9. How does anchoring (the first speaker setting the frame) distort collective perception? Design a meeting start protocol that mitigates anchoring.

10. In intelligence analysis, "competitive hypothesis testing" forces analysts to consider multiple explanations simultaneously. How does this improve collective perception?
11. Describe a situation where your team's collective perception was significantly better than any individual's perception. What enabled this?
12. Describe a situation where your team's collective perception was worse than the best individual's perception. What went wrong?
13. Design a system for your organization to aggregate frontline employee observations into strategic intelligence. Specify the collection mechanism, aggregation method, and feedback loop.
14. How would you structure a strategy review meeting to maximize perceptual diversity while minimizing cascading effects?
15. Your team is evaluating a potential acquisition target. Design a structured perception process that leverages different team members' expertise while preventing groupthink.
16. How can anonymous feedback mechanisms improve collective perception? What are the limitations of anonymity?
17. Remote teams lose many non-verbal perceptual cues. What specific collective sensing mechanisms need to be redesigned for distributed teams?
18. How does organizational culture affect collective perception? Can a team perceive truths that the culture considers unacceptable?
19. Compare statistical aggregation (averaging estimates) with deliberative aggregation (group discussion). When is each more appropriate?
20. Design a "collective sensing exercise" for your team that surfaces hidden information each member holds but hasn't shared.